Follow the Bullet (Group 6): Speaker Script

MCCJ 527 | 10-minute group presentation | 6 members × 2 slides × ~50 seconds each

Tips: *Text in [square brackets] is a stage cue, not something to say aloud. Each slide is about 110–130 words, roughly 50 seconds at a calm pace. Practise once with a timer.*

MEMBER 1 – Roll 27 – [Your Name]

Slide 1: Title: Follow the Bullet (about 50 seconds)

[Hold up an imaginary bullet between two fingers.] Imagine one bullet. It was made in China decades ago, stored in a depot in Albania, sold through a broker on a terrorist watch list, repackaged to hide where it came from, and finally handed to a soldier in Afghanistan. And the money for it flowed all the way back to two young men in Miami.

Good morning. We are Group 6, and our film is War Dogs, from 2016. Today, instead of retelling the movie, we are going to follow the bullet, and follow the money, stop by stop. At every stop we will pause at a "criminology checkpoint" to see which concepts from our course are at work.

Let me show you the route.

Slide 2: Route overview and the film (about 50 seconds)

Here is our route. *[Trace the copper line.]* Stop one, Miami, where the story begins. Stop two, Jordan and Iraq, the first risky deal. Stop three, Las Vegas, where they meet the broker. Stops four and five, Albania, where the ammunition is found, and hidden. Stop six, Kabul, where it ends up. And the dashed teal line is the money, flowing back to Miami, and finally into a courtroom.

[Right panel.] The film is War Dogs, from 2016, directed by Todd Phillips and starring Jonah Hill and Miles Teller. It is a crime comedy, but it is based on the true story reported by Guy Lawson. Its theme: people who profit from war without ever fighting it.

[Member 2], take us to stop one.

MEMBER 2 – Roll 8 – [Your Name]

Slide 3: Stop 1 – Miami: strain and differential association (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 1]. Stop one: Miami. *[Point to the tracker.]*

David is a broke massage therapist with a baby on the way. He meets his childhood friend Efraim, whose company AEY bids online for the crumbs of Pentagon procurement: small contracts that big companies ignore. At this point, the bullet hasn't been bought yet. The money is simply sitting in public tenders.

[Checkpoint.] Two theories explain why David joins. Merton's strain theory: he accepts the goal of wealth but has no legitimate way to reach it, so he "innovates". Messner and Rosenfeld would add that money starts to override family values. And Sutherland's differential association: David learns both the methods and the excuses from Efraim.

Next stop: the Middle East.

Slide 4: Stop 2 – Jordan → Iraq: enterprise model and rational choice (about 50 seconds)

Stop two: Jordan and Iraq. A shipment of pistols for the Iraqi police is stuck at the border in Jordan. Instead of losing the contract, David and Efraim fly to Amman, use local fixers, and drive the cargo into Iraq themselves. It works, they get paid, and bigger contracts follow.

[Checkpoint.] This is Smith's enterprise model in action. Legal and illegal business sit on one spectrum, driven by the same market. AEY started with legal bidding; now it has slid into grey dealing with fixers.

And it is classic rational choice: a calculated gamble with a high reward. And because the gamble pays off, it encourages the next, bigger one.

[Member 3], take us to Las Vegas.

MEMBER 3 – Roll 37 – [Your Name]

Slide 5: Stop 3 – Las Vegas: network, patron–client, crime–terror nexus (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 2]. Stop three: Las Vegas. At an arms fair, the pair meet Henry Girard, played by Bradley Cooper. Henry is on a terrorist watch list, so he cannot sell to the US government directly. But he has access to about 100 million rounds of ammunition in Albania. AEY needs supply; Henry needs a clean American front.

[Checkpoint.] This is Morselli's network model: power belongs to brokers who connect worlds that cannot reach each other. It is also Albini's patron–client model: Henry offers access in exchange for a share. And it shows the crime–terror nexus: someone barred from legal trade simply borrows a clean name.

[Bottom note.] Henry is a composite character, inspired by a real Swiss broker.

Slide 6: Stop 4 – Albania: corruption and Klitgaard's formula (about 50 seconds)

Stop four: Albania. The ammunition sits in old state depots. To reach it, AEY has to work through local intermediaries and officials, and each one takes a share. Meanwhile, Efraim starts trying to cut Henry out.

[Checkpoint.] This is where corruption enters. Transparency International defines it as the abuse of entrusted power for private gain. And Klitgaard's formula explains why it flourishes here: corruption equals monopoly plus discretion minus accountability. Henry has a monopoly on access. Officials and fixers have wide discretion. And in wartime, accountability is weak.

[Bottom note.] One thing the film leaves out: in March 2008, an explosion at the Gërdec ammunition depot in Albania killed 26 people, and senior officials were charged.

[Member 4], to the repack.

MEMBER 4 – Roll 33 – [Your Name]

Slide 7: Stop 5 – The repack: white-collar crime and neutralization (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 3]. Stop five: the repack. This is the point of no return. David discovers that the ammunition was made in China, which is banned under a US arms embargo, and by the contract itself. Instead of reporting it, they have the rounds repackaged to remove the Chinese markings, and pass them off as Albanian. This really happened.

[Checkpoint.] This is white-collar crime in Sutherland's sense: respectable businessmen committing crime in the course of their work.

And how do they live with it? Sykes and Matza's techniques of neutralization. "The troops still get working bullets", that's denial of injury. "The government buys from shady sources too", that's condemning the condemners. These are our paraphrases of their attitudes.

Slide 8: Stop 6 – Kabul: the UNTOC definition (about 50 seconds)

Stop six: Kabul. The decades-old ammunition is delivered to the Afghan National Army. The victims barely appear on screen: soldiers relying on old ammunition, and taxpayers who paid for the contract.

[Checkpoint.] So, having followed the whole chain: is this organized crime? Under Article 2 of the UN Convention against Transnational Organized Crime, yes. It is a structured group of three or more people: Efraim, David, their financier, Henry and the suppliers. It existed over time, and it committed serious crime for material benefit.

And it is transnational organized crime: it crossed five countries, exploiting the gaps between their laws.

[Member 5], take us to the final stop.

MEMBER 5 – Roll 24 – [Your Name]

Slide 9: Stop 7 – Courtroom: why AEY is not the mafia (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 4]. Stop seven: a federal courtroom in Miami. Greed and betrayal break the partnership, journalists expose AEY, and the government investigates. In the film, as in real life, Efraim is sentenced to four years in prison, and David, who cooperates, to seven months of house arrest.

[Checkpoint.] But here is the twist. If we use Abadinsky's classic attributes of organized crime, AEY mostly fails the test. No hierarchy, no exclusive membership, no code, and it collapsed the moment its leaders were charged. It is not the mafia.

So our classification is organized white-collar crime, made possible by what Kramer and colleagues call state-corporate crime: a government outsourcing war to the lowest bidder, with weak vetting.

Slide 10: Arrival: which model explains the journey (about 50 seconds)

We've arrived. Now let's look back at the whole route and ask which model of organized crime explains it best.

[Top row.] Smith's enterprise model fits strongly: across stops one to five, AEY slides from legal bidding, to fixers, to fraud, as demand grows.

[Second row.] Morselli's network model also fits strongly: at stops three and four, power sits with the brokers bridging the Pentagon and the Balkan stockpiles.

[Third row.] Albini's patron–client model fits partly: Henry trades access for a share.

[Bottom row.] And Cressey's hierarchical model, the mafia model, fits weakly: there are no ranks and no code, and the group collapses after the arrests.

[Member 6] will give our final evaluation.

MEMBER 6 – Roll 21 – [Your Name]

Slide 11: The verdict: is the film accurate? (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 5]. So, after following the bullet all the way, is the film accurate? Our verdict: accurate in substance, exaggerated in style.

[Left.] What it gets right: it breaks the mafia stereotype and shows crime as a business. It fits the UN definition and the enterprise and network models. Its characters never see themselves as criminals. And the core facts are real: the 298-million-dollar contract, the repackaging and the sentences.

[Right.] What it gets wrong: the comedy glamorizes the money. Henry is a composite and the Albanian threats were invented. It blames two young men rather than the system that let them in. And it leaves out real victims, including the 26 people killed in the Gërdec explosion.

Slide 12: End of the line: conclusion (about 50 seconds)

So here is where our journey ends. *[Read slowly.]* Follow the bullet, and you find a business. Follow the money, and you find the system.

Our answer: AEY is organized crime under the UN definition, but it is not the mafia. It is organized white-collar crime, best explained by the enterprise and network models, and made possible by weak oversight.

And the lesson for Bangladesh: our own large procurement projects also rely on middlemen. Vetting contractors, disclosing who really owns a company, and checking where goods come from is not just paperwork. It is crime prevention.

Thank you. We are happy to take your questions.